

YE'ORTODOKS TEWAHEDO HAYMANOT · THE ORTHODOX TEWAHEDO
FAITH

Raising Children in the Orthodox Tewahedo Faith

A guide for parents — helping children know, love, and live for God through prayer, worship,
Scripture, and the life of the Church.



Ethiopian & Eritrean Orthodox Tewahedo Church · Family Catechesis



The Heart of the Matter

The goal is not only to teach children about the faith — but to help them grow into faithful Orthodox Christians.

Raising children in the Orthodox Tewahedo faith is centered on helping them know, love, and live for God. The home, the parish, and the grace of God work together — and faith is passed on far more by what children witness every day than by what they are told.

Prayer

Daily, together, aloud

Worship

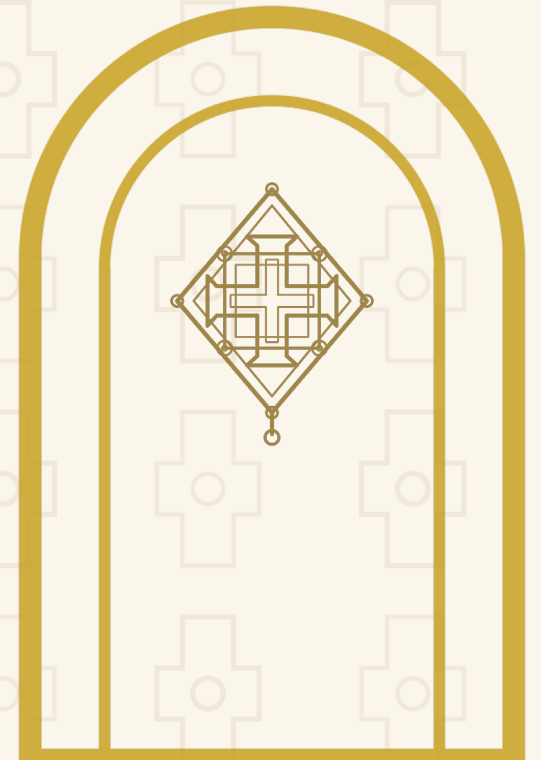
The Divine Liturgy

Scripture

Read and discussed

The Church

Sacraments &
community



Ten Pillars of Raising a Child in the Faith

Each is explored in the slides that follow

1

Build a Christ-Centered Home

2

Participate in Church Life

3

Teach the Orthodox Faith

4

Encourage Daily Prayer

5

Read the Bible Together

6

Teach by Example

7

Teach Fasting Gradually

8

Encourage Service & Charity

9

Teach Respect for Family

10

Love the Orthodox Heritage

1

Build a Christ-Centered Home

- ◇ Begin and end each day with family prayer.
- ◇ Keep icons, a cross, and a Bible in the home.
- ◇ Celebrate Orthodox feasts and fasts together.
- ◇ Let children see parents praying, reading Scripture, and living the faith.



**The home is the
first church**

*Habits formed at home become the faith carried
for life.*



"Train up a child in the way he should go, and when he is old he will not depart from it."

— Proverbs 22:6

2

Participate Regularly in Church Life



Divine Liturgy

Attend every Sunday and on the major feast days of the Church.



The Holy Mysteries

Bring children to receive the Sacraments — especially Holy Communion, after proper preparation.



Sunday School & Youth

Encourage participation in Sunday school, youth groups, and parish events.



Reverence in Church

Teach children how to stand, pray, and behave respectfully in the house of God.

3

Teach the Orthodox Faith

What every child should come to know



The Holy Trinity

Father, Son, and Holy Spirit — one God.



The Life of Christ

His birth, ministry, death, and resurrection.



Holy Scripture

Stories from both the Old and New Testaments.



Saints & Martyrs

The lives of those who loved Christ above all.



The Seven Sacraments

The meaning and grace of each Mystery.



St. Mary & the Angels

The honor due the Theotokos and the heavenly hosts.

4

Encourage Daily Prayer

Begin simply, then grow into the prayers of the Church

A gradual path

- ◇ Teach simple prayers first, in the child's own words.
- ◇ The Lord's Prayer
- ◇ Morning and evening prayers
- ◇ Short prayers before meals and at bedtime
- ◇ Then introduce the traditional prayers of the Church.



The Trisagion

*“Holy God, Holy Mighty,
Holy Immortal...”*

Repeated daily, these words become a child's own voice
before God.



Read the Bible Together

Read age-appropriate passages — then talk about them

1

Creation

2

Noah's Ark

3

Abraham

4

Moses

5

David and Goliath

6

**The Nativity of
Christ**

7

**The Miracles of
Jesus**

8

**The Crucifixion and
Resurrection**

Ask what the story shows about God, and what it asks of us — discussion turns a story into faith.

6

Teach by Example

Children learn most from what they see

Love

Humility

Forgiveness

Honesty

Patience

Respect

Parents are the living lesson. A child who sees forgiveness offered at home learns mercy long before it is ever explained — and what is practiced daily is what is remembered for life.

7

Teach Fasting Gradually



**Fasting is an act of love and
obedience to God**

*Never presented as punishment — but as a gift the Church gives
us to draw nearer to Christ.*

1

Explain first

Help children understand why the Church fasts before asking them to fast.

2

Introduce slowly

As children grow older, bring them gradually into the fasting traditions.

3

Guided by the priest

Follow the guidance of your priest or spiritual father for each child.



Encourage Service and Charity

Faith becomes real when it is given away



Help those in need

Let children take part in giving, not only in watching it happen.



Share with others

Generosity is learned in small, ordinary moments.



Visit the sick and elderly

Where appropriate, bring children along to comfort and honor them.



Give thanks to God

Teach gratitude for every blessing, large and small.



*“Freely you have
received, freely give.”*

Matthew 10:8



Teach Respect for Family and Elders

The Orthodox Tewahedo Church emphasizes honoring:



God



Parents



**Priests &
Spiritual Fathers**



Elders



Teachers

Respect learned in the home becomes reverence offered to God.



"Honor your father and your mother."

— Exodus 20:12

10

Help Them Love Their Orthodox Heritage



Our History

The Ethiopian and Eritrean Orthodox Tewahedo Church.



The Councils

The first three Ecumenical Councils.



The 81 Books

The full Orthodox biblical canon.



Living Tradition

Mezmur, Ge'ez, and the liturgical calendar.

Saints to know and love



St. Tekle Haymanot



St. Yared



St. George



The Nine Saints

A child who knows where the faith came from is far less likely to leave it.

Practical Tips by Age

Meet each child where they are

Ages 3–6

- ◇ Simple Bible stories
- ◇ Short prayers
- ◇ Church songs
- ◇ Coloring icons and Bible scenes

Ages 7–12

- ◇ Read Scripture together
- ◇ Learn the Creed
- ◇ Understand feast days and fasting
- ◇ Begin serving in church where appropriate

Teenagers

- ◇ Discuss their questions openly
- ◇ Encourage regular confession and Communion
- ◇ Connect faith to school, friendships, and daily decisions
- ◇ Join youth ministries and service projects

The Role of Parents

In the Orthodox Tewahedo tradition, parents are the first teachers of the faith.

By consistently praying together, attending church, practicing the commandments, and showing Christ's love in daily life, parents create an environment where children can develop a lasting relationship with God.



Pray

together, daily

Worship

as a whole family

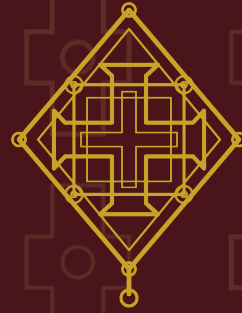
Practice

the commandments

Show

Christ's love

Supported by the family, the parish, and the grace of God.



A Lifelong Journey

*The Church teaches that raising children in the faith is a lifelong journey of love,
patience, discipline, and example — supported by the family, the parish, and the grace of
God.*



Sibhat le'Egziabher · Glory be to God